

HOW A CAR WORKS

Most early Ts were open top, with a folding soft top to keep off the rain.

In cars that run on gasoline or diesel, the engine is powered by burning the fuel inside cylinders. As the fuel burns, it expands and pushes on pistons, rotating a crankshaft. The crankshaft then turns gears, which adjust the balance between speed and power.

The gears turn rods called half-shafts to drive the wheels.

Engine burns fuel in cylinders to provide power.

Gearbox adjusts the balance of power and speed.

Half-shafts drive the front wheels around.

Differential gear balances the power to each wheel.

AIRBAGS

Safety is a vital part of car design. Many modern cars have airbags, which blow up instantly to cushion passengers in a crash. When they were invented in the 1960s, airbags were inflated with compressed air. Now, the impact triggers a chemical reaction, which instantly creates swelling bubbles of gas to fill the bag.



Airbag and dummy used in a crash test

The wheels, like those of a bicycle, were wire-spoked, making them cheap and light.

Front parking sensors alert the driver of nearby obstacles.



ADDED FEATURES

Cars are developing all the time—existing features are improved and new features are added. Cars may also be built with extra technology, including parking sensors (left), defoggers, navigation systems, backup cameras, and automatic emergency brakes. In a few years, people may be able to sit back and command the car to drive them to a destination.